gradations of meaning and mood just by a change in just one of them. There can be precision or ambiguity brought in by such changes, depending on the intent.

~

Like India, China has seen the rise and fall of empires; and it has been occupied and ruled by non-Han people. It is true, however, that during these periods of foreign rule, institutions, rituals and structure of governance displayed remarkable continuity. The bureaucratic elite and the literati continued to serve their foreign masters even though there may have been resentment and bitterness over their having to do this. In the retelling of Chinese history, the alien character of the Mongol Yuan and Manchu Qing dynasties is muted, and they have joined the continuous stream of Chinese history as fully Sinicized entities.

We have witnessed this in more contemporary times too. During the late nineteenth century and early twentieth century, there was a strong political movement against the Qing dynasty, which was attacked as alien rule tyrannizing the Chinese people. The well-known Chinese revolutionary leader Sun Yat-sen launched a bitter attack against Qing rule. For him, revolution meant the ousting of the Manchu rulers rather than rejection of Western imperialism. This was echoed by several Chinese scholars and political figures.

And yet, in harking back to the ‘century of humiliation’ spanning the period from the Opium Wars of the 1840s until 1949, the two and a half centuries of the tyranny of Qing rule is no longer mentioned. The target gradually shifted, almost unnoticed, to Western depredations against China. In this retelling, the Qing became domesticated as a Chinese national regime which had to suffer humiliation at the hands of Western imperialists. This enabled the regimes that followed the Qing to claim inheritance to the extensive territories the Qing had added to the empire, including those like Tibet, over which a fictional suzerainty was maintained.

This may also be contrasted with the subsequent Chinese depiction of colonial India as a slave country, as if its own history under Manchu